Working for a wage

Before the invention of industrial machinery, most people worked on the land, which was owned by a few royal or noble families. Peasant farmers grew crops and raised animals to provide food, cloth, and fuel. Agriculture, and to a lesser extent the mining of metals and minerals, formed the basis for the economy, and in many poor countries this is still the case.

Things changed dramatically with the advent of mechanization. Mills could produce goods such as flour and cloth in huge quantities, and factories appeared that could mass-produce all kinds of manufactured goods. These mills and factories provided jobs, and many workers were attracted by the prospect of earning money rather than living off the land. As they moved from the country to where the work was, large industrial cities grew.

> IT IS QUESTIONABLE IF ALL THE MECHANICAL INVENTIONS YET MADE HAVE LIGHTENED THE DAY'S TOIL OF ANY HUMAN BEING.
>
> JOHN STUART MILL

Growth and prosperity

There was a change too in the economic system. Rather than producing food for landowning masters, and keeping some for themselves, workers were paid a wage by the owners of the factories and mills. The owners were a new class of entrepreneurs, who owned the means of production—the buildings and machinery. These are sometimes known as capital goods, and so the